

Logos: wordmarks, marks, and lockups

Week 8, Lecture 1, Design for Builders: Ship Beautiful Products as a Founder

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- The three logo types and why most startups default to a wordmark
- The silhouette test: the fastest way to know if a logo has real identity
- Designing for two extremes: the 16px favicon and the 1200x630 OG image
- Negative space: the invisible element that separates considered logos from defaults
- Lockup variants: horizontal, stacked, and icon-only

Part 1: three logo types

Wordmark, mark, and combo

Every logo is one of three types:

- **Wordmark**, the product name set in a typeface, with or without letterform modifications (Google, Figma, Slack)
- **Logo mark**, an abstract or pictorial symbol that stands alone, independent of text (Apple, Twitter/X, Nike)
- **Combo mark**, wordmark and mark used together, with rules for when each can appear alone (Spotify, Airbnb, GitHub)

The type you choose depends on how much equity your brand has built and whether your name is visually memorable on its own (Chris Do, The Futur 2022).

Why most startups ship a wordmark

Marks require visual equity before they communicate anything.

- The Nike swoosh took years to stand alone without “Nike”
- An unknown mark is just a shape: it communicates nothing about the product
- A wordmark communicates the name immediately, everywhere, at every size

For a product with zero existing audience: a wordmark is almost always right.

A mark earns independence after the audience already knows the name.

When a mark makes sense from day one

Three cases where a standalone mark works before you have equity:

1. **The product name is hard to set legibly at small sizes**, long names, unusual letter combinations, or hyphenated names collapse at favicon scale
2. **The product operates internationally**, a mark crosses languages where a wordmark does not
3. **The mark IS the product**, icon-first products like app icons, where the mark appears in the OS chrome before any marketing context

Most SaaS founders are not in any of these three cases.

Part 2: the silhouette test

What the silhouette test reveals

Fill every layer of the logo solid black. Look at the resulting shape.

- Does it have a distinct outline?
- Could you recognize it as this logo even without knowing what it says?
- Is the overall form interesting, or is it just a rectangle of grey letterforms?

Chris Do (The Futur, 2022) describes this as the most reliable single test for whether a logo has real visual identity. A logo that depends on its typeface rendering for all its character is fragile: it will disappear on dark backgrounds, at small sizes, and in low-fidelity contexts like embroidery or stamps.

What makes a silhouette distinctive

Three sources of silhouette character:

- **Modified ascenders or descenders**, a letterform that extends above or below the normal range creates a shape that is not just a flat-topped rectangle
- **An attached or integrated mark**, a geometric element that extends the wordmark changes its overall outline
- **Letter-spacing extremes**, very tight or very wide spacing changes the silhouette from compact to airy, and that difference reads in the shadow

None of these require complex illustration. One letterform change is enough.

Negative space

Negative space is the area inside and around the letterforms that the designer controls without adding ink.

- The FedEx arrow: the space between the E and the x creates an arrow that is never drawn
- The Amazon smile: the arc from A to Z reads as a smile and as a delivery promise
- A simple wordmark: the counters inside letters like O, e, a, and g are negative space you can modify

For a product logo, you do not need a hidden arrow. You need negative space that looks deliberate rather than accidental. The difference is whether the spaces feel consistent with each other in size and rhythm (Mayfield 2022).

Part 3: designing for two sizes

The favicon: 16x16px

A favicon renders at 16x16 device-independent pixels on a browser tab.

At that size, a wordmark is almost always illegible. The letterforms merge into a grey band.

The practical rules:

- **One or two letterforms maximum**, the product initial, or the first two characters if both are distinctive
- **High contrast**, no hairline strokes, no delicate serifs, no fine details
- **Distinct form**, the favicon must be identifiable in a row of other favicons: Google, Gmail, Figma, Notion

Test your favicon candidate next to the tabs you keep open most.

The OG image: 1200x630px

An OG image (Open Graph) is the preview image that appears when your URL is shared on social media, in Slack, in iMessage.

At 1200x630, you have room for the full wordmark plus context. The design challenge here is the opposite of the favicon:

- Too much whitespace reads as low-effort at thumbnail scale
- The logo must be legible when the OG image renders as a 300x157 thumbnail
- Brand color used as the background does more work than a white background

Test by viewing the image at 25% scale. If the logo and value proposition are readable at that size, the OG image works.

Favicon vs OG: the same logo, two problems

- Reduce to one or two letterforms
 - No detail
 - Must survive a row of 10 competitor favicons
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- Full wordmark has room to breathe
 - Add context: tagline or product category
 - Test at thumbnail scale, not full size

Favicon (16x16)

OG image (1200x630)

Both derive from the same logo system. The mark handles the favicon. The wordmark handles the OG. Neither can do both jobs.

Part 4: lockups

What a lockup is

A **logo lockup** is a predefined arrangement of the wordmark, mark, and any accompanying text (tagline, product family label, company name).

Three standard lockups:

- **Horizontal**, mark to the left, wordmark to the right. Used in wide contexts: headers, email footers, presentation headers
- **Stacked**, mark above, wordmark below. Used in square contexts: app icons in larger format, social profile images at medium size
- **Icon-only**, mark alone. Used in small contexts: favicon, app icon, loading spinner

Defining these three in advance prevents the logo from being assembled ad-hoc every time.

Clear space rules

Every logo system defines a minimum clear space around the logo.

The simplest rule: the height of the capital letter in the wordmark defines the minimum margin on all four sides.

Why it matters:

- A logo touching the edge of its container looks like a layout error, not a design decision
- Clear space rules let any contributor (a contractor, a new hire, a developer) place the logo correctly without asking

One slide, one rule, no guesswork.

What to define before you need it

A logo system is not finished until you have answered these questions:

- What is the minimum size the wordmark can appear before legibility breaks?
- What color versions exist? (Dark on light, light on dark, single-color, black, white)
- What file formats are production-ready? (SVG for web, PNG with alpha for presentation, PDF for print)
- Which lockup is the default when no other guidance is given?

Define these once. Put them on the brand sheet. You will never answer those questions again.

Take-aways

1. A wordmark is almost always right for an early-stage product. A mark earns independence after the audience knows the name.
2. The silhouette test: fill everything black. If the shape is not distinctive in silhouette, the logo depends on rendering quality it may not always have.
3. Negative space works when it is deliberate. The counters of letterforms are the easiest place to introduce it.
4. The favicon and OG image are opposite problems: the favicon demands reduction, the OG image demands context.
5. Define three lockups (horizontal, stacked, icon-only) before you need them. Put the clear-space rule on the brand sheet.

"A logo doesn't sell the company. It identifies it. The story behind the logo is what gives it power."

Chris Do, The Futur, "The Power of Design: Chris Do on Brand Logos," 2022

What's next

- **This week, Lecture 2:** Brand systems beyond the logo: voice and tone, brand colors vs UI colors, photography direction, and the one-page brand sheet
- **This week, section:** Logo studio, ship three wordmark drafts and pick one with peer critique
- **Reading:** Week 8 reading at </c/design-for-builders-26au/readings/wk08>
- **HW4 assigned this week:** Brand sheet for your product

